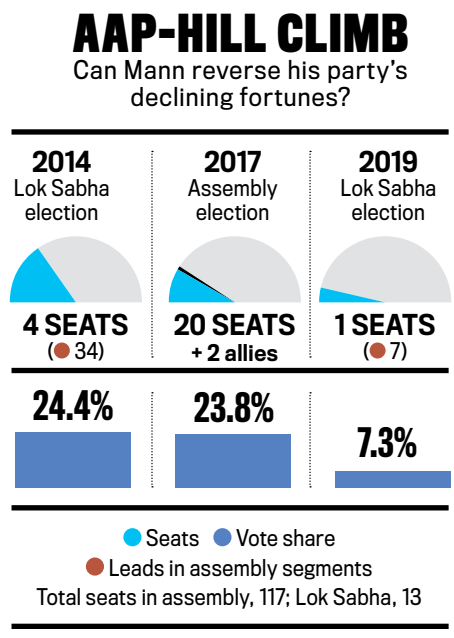


NARINDER NANU/GETTY IMAGES

ICE COOL
Mann's conservative look today versus his earlier clean-shaven avatar



Bajwa naal nahi bandi, us Bajwa di Tript Bajwa naal nahi bandi, Bajwa di Sidhu naal nahi bandi, ate Sidhu di kisse naal nahi bandi." (The relevant phrase is '*X di Y naal nahi bandi*'—this one doesn't get along with that one, and Sidhu doesn't get along with anyone!)

Automatically, through this perpetual poll campaign of sorts, a case was being built up for the AAP. The time too is propitious. The incumbent Congress, worn down by dissension, faces charges of not having done enough—on farm debt waivers, drug trafficking, or the instances of sacrilege. The Badal family is tainted by perceived patronage of the culprits of the latter two, and allegations of corruption at family-controlled gurudwaras. And the BJP is still facing resistance from the dominant Jat Sikh community.

In short, it's an electorate disgruntled with mainstream parties—in times of general financial stress. Imagine its susceptibility to the seductive charms of Kejriwal's freebie mela: Rs 1,000 to 9.9 million women, free power up to 300 units et al. Economist Charan Singh calls it "dangerous populism"—an AAP regime would need Rs 12,000 crore per year just to dole out those goodies. The monthly GST collection in Punjab is only around Rs 1,800 crore, not enough even for the thousand-per-woman, after salaries, pensions et al. But AAP sees this as its moment in Punjab and wants to leave nothing to chance. Debuting in state polls in 2017, the party managed 20 seats, with 23.8 per cent votes. But it couldn't hold on to these gains. Eight of its MLAs quit the party. In 2019, Mann was the lone winner; AAP candidates failed to get even a sixth of the valid votes polled in the other 12 LS seats.

Seeking to reclaim centrestage, the party realised it needed a face—something its rivals lack at present. AAP leaders are already being accused of corruption in ticket distribution. Even if Kejriwal rubbished farm leader Balbir Rajewal's audio evidence, the taint became rather public when partymen ransacked AAP's co-state in-charge Raghav Chadha's presser on similar allegations. Ferozepur Rural candidate Amandeep Banger pointed fingers at Chadha, saying AAP runs like a "multinational company", with Delhi leaders calling the shots. Having Mann at the steering wheel will stymie such talk.

In other ways too, the AAP seems to have learnt some lessons from its 2017 fiasco—witness the care with which it's orienting itself to Punjab's various religious and social sectors, and tamping down on its old tendency to make "shoot and scoot" allegations. (In 2018, Kejriwal had to write an apology to SAD's Bikramjit Majithia for making "unsubstantiated" allegations on drug trafficking.) This time, Kejriwal is frequenting Hindu temples and promising pilgrim buses to Ayodhya, Varanasi and the Hanuman temple at Salasar Dham, in Rajasthan's Jhunjhunu. The party's also maintaining a distance from radical leaders and their narratives. After the January 5 security scare around the PM's motorcade, AAP conspicuously chose to criticise the state government—again, the intention was to not contribute to any Hindu paranoia about national security.

All this relates to Punjab's complex community matrices. The Jat Sikhs have an uneasy relationship with Dalits (Hindu or Sikh) as well as caste Hindus. Earlier, AAP was banking on mobilising Jat Sikhs, backing the farm agitation to the hilt. Post the repeal of the farm laws, and with the Congress putting up Charanjit Singh Channi as Punjab's first Dalit CM, all equations changed. SAD started consolidating again behind the Badals, and Akali-backed unions returned to back its candidates. And Rajewal's farmers' front is taking away Jat Sikhs with left/ socialist leanings—those who once backed the Congress and, in 2017, voted AAP. Retaining their loyalties will need negotiations at the local level: Mann, a Jat Sikh, will be handy.

A counter-mobilisation is unfolding in urban Punjab, but the AAP will find it difficult to scoop up any benefits there, despite its overtures to the Hindu business class. The BJP is their natural choice, and Mann has almost no pull among them. His value lies elsewhere, but he will need more space in decision-making to maximise that. Only according him that stature will allow the party to counter Channi's pro-people image, or the challenge posed by the farm unions contesting on all 117 seats. The AAP has announced candidates in 109 of those, but for the campaign to truly take off, it needs a son of the soil. Post 1984, no one has succeeded if there's a perception of dependence on the high command in New Delhi. Amarinder too always ran his campaigns as a local leader. It's time, then, for some Garma Garam Grillo. ■